SAÉ 5

English part

Benchmark: Les Jardins de Cocagne compared to similar organisations abroad

A competitive / comparative market analysis

Introduction

This report compares the French Cocagne network (Réseau Cocagne) to four comparable organisations operating abroad, each combining organic vegetable growing with a social mission of some kind. For each organisation, the report presents a short introduction, a review of the organisation's website (content, navigation, visual design, and self-service features), and a table summarising its main strengths and weaknesses. A final comparative table and a conclusion close the study.

Two international concepts, which have no exact one-word equivalent in French, are useful to understand the sector before looking at individual organisations. Community Supported Agriculture (CSA) is a direct partnership between a farm and a group of consumers, who pay in advance for a share of the harvest delivered regularly over a season; it is the closest English-language equivalent to the French “panier” / “AMAP” model, and the term recurs throughout the foreign websites reviewed below. WWOOF (World-Wide Opportunities on Organic Farms) is a different, older concept: an international network through which volunteers exchange a few hours of work on an organic farm each day for food and lodging, with no wage and no formal employment relationship. It is not itself a Cocagne-type organisation there is no paid, structured reintegration pathway but it is a useful point of comparison because it shows an alternative, purely voluntary way of linking organic farm work to a social objective (here, education and cultural exchange rather than employment).

Looking at the wider CSA landscape abroad also makes clear that not every organic box scheme carries a social mission. Good Box Organics, a Los Angeles-area vegetable-box service listed on LocalHarvest, describes itself as a “3rd-party CSA service” sourcing from several partner farms for paying households a purely commercial delivery business with no stated employment or reintegration programme. Food for Health, a programme of the AIDS Healthcare Foundation, is at the opposite extreme: it distributes free groceries, including produce bought from local farms, to people facing food insecurity, but it does not grow food itself and has no work-integration component either. Neither organisation was therefore selected as a full comparator below, but both help to frame what makes the Cocagne model distinctive: the combination, in a single structure, of organic production, a subscription-basket sales model, and paid, structured work integration for people who are far from employment.

Selection criteria: the organisations compared below were chosen because each pairs certified or de-facto organic production with a formal social mission or an explicit solidarity purpose, rather than being a purely commercial CSA operator or a purely charitable food-distribution programme. They cover five different national contexts (the United States, the United Kingdom, Canada, Italy and Switzerland) and several different legal forms (a non-profit corporation, a workers' cooperative, a network of social cooperatives, and a regional federation), which allows the comparison to highlight how local legal and cultural context shapes both the on-the-ground project and its online presentation.

Reading grid used for each organisation

To keep the five reviews comparable, each organisation is read against the same four questions: What is the organisation's social mission, and how central is it to its communication? What does the organisation sell, and through which channels? What does the public website look like, and how easy is it to navigate? And, crucially for a benchmark feeding into a software project, how much can a client do online, by themselves, without contacting staff subscribing, pausing, choosing a drop-off point, or paying?

1. Les Jardins de Cocagne (France) reference organisation

Réseau Cocagne https://www.reseaucocagne.org/

The Jardins de Cocagne are organic market-gardening farms whose purpose is to offer a path back into work for

people who are far from employment. Most are non-profit associations (1901 law) officially recognised as an “Atelier et Chantier d'Insertion”; a few operate as a SCIC (cooperative) instead. On average, a Jardin supports around 22 employees on integration contracts (1 to 24 months), growing 70 to 80 vegetable varieties, sold mainly through weekly basket subscriptions to members, alongside retail sales, professional orders, and, in some Jardins, diversification activities (processing, education, green-space maintenance). Close to a hundred Jardins across France belong to the Réseau Cocagne, the national network that supports professionalisation and shares tools between structures, without any hierarchical link between the network and individual Jardins.

Cocagne's current software is an ageing Microsoft Access tool built in the 2000s: still used by 65% of Jardins as of 2016, it covers basic subscription and payment management and prints delivery route sheets, but it is a single-user desktop database with no online access for either staff or clients, and no self-service front office at all. As the Jardins' commercial formulas have diversified, 75% of Jardins have expressed an urgent need for a new tool, which is the origin of the SAÉ 5 project: a shared, open-source, highly configurable back office and front office, hosted centrally in SaaS mode, that each Jardin can adapt to its own way of working.

Because there are close to a hundred Jardins, each with its own local practices, legal form, and sales channels, the network's challenge is less about lacking a social mission or a customer base both are well established than about giving every one of these structures a shared, adaptable digital tool without forcing them into a single rigid workflow. This is the backdrop against which the other five organisations below should be read: each of them solves a smaller piece of the same underlying problem, usually for a single site rather than a federated network of nearly a hundred.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Strong, nationally recognised social mission combining organic farming with paid work-integration contracts.	Existing tool is a 2000s single-user Access database with no online or self-service access for clients.
National network (Réseau Cocagne) already pools knowledge and tools across close to 100 structures.	No shared, mutualised digital platform yet: each Jardin runs its own local, disconnected copy of the old tool.
Wide, well-established sales model: basket subscriptions, retail, and professional sales.	Individual Jardins generally have little to no online presence for managing subscriptions or drop-off points.

2. Homeless Garden Project (Santa Cruz, California, USA)

https://homelessgardenproject.org/

The Homeless Garden Project (HGP) is a non-profit organisation that provides job training, transitional employment and support services to people experiencing homelessness. Participants work for up to twelve months on a certified organic farm, earning an hourly wage while meeting weekly with social workers. HGP's organic vegetables, herbs and flowers are sold through a CSA programme, a farm stand, and a line of value-added products available in local stores and online. Like the Cocagne network, HGP treats agricultural work less as an end in itself than as a structured, therapeutic pathway back into stable employment and housing.

The HGP website is a modern WordPress site with a clean, nature-toned design that conveys the mission through large photographs of trainees at work. Navigation is organised into clear sections About Us, Our Work, Programs, Give & Get Involved, and Shop. The online store is integrated through Shopify, giving the site genuine e-commerce functionality, and CSA shares (Pick-Up or U-Pick) are purchased directly from a dedicated collection page though nothing on the public site lets a member pause a week or change their pick-up day themselves once subscribed.

Measured against the reading grid, HGP scores very well on mission communication and on retail e-commerce, but poorly on ongoing subscriber autonomy: once a share is purchased, adjusting it is a matter of emailing or calling the farm rather than logging into an account, which is exactly the kind of task the Cocagne front office is meant to remove from staff's plate.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Warm, mission-driven visual identity with authentic photography and testimonials.	Dense navigation with many nested sub-menus can feel overwhelming.
Fully functional integrated online shop (Shopify) for shares and value-added products.	No self-service for pausing, editing or rescheduling a subscription once purchased.
Clear multi-channel structure (CSA, farm stand, wholesale, retail stores).	Single collection point only (the farm itself); no drop-off-point network to manage.

3. OrganicLea (London, United Kingdom)

https://organiclea.org.uk/

OrganicLea is a workers' cooperative growing food on the eastern edge of London. Run collectively by its worker-members, it farms a twelve-acre site using organic and agroecological methods, distributing vegetables through a weekly box scheme, a farm stall, and plant and compost sales, while running accredited horticultural training, school visits, and a “Garden of Sanctuary” programme for refugees and asylum seekers. Its ambition to “transform the food system” gives it a more overtly political dimension than most Cocagne gardens.

OrganicLea's WordPress-and-WooCommerce website is functional and information-rich. The box-scheme section offers a genuine account system: new customers sign up online and existing customers log in to a customer dashboard, choosing among several neighbourhood pick-up points and managing their order and holiday dates from there the closest of all five organisations to the client-side autonomy the Cocagne project is aiming for.

Measured against the reading grid, OrganicLea is the strongest of the five comparators on client autonomy, even if that comes at the cost of a less polished visual identity than some of the others a trade-off worth noting, since the Cocagne project explicitly wants both a functional front office and a friendly, intuitive interface, rather than having to choose between them.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Real customer account with self-service order, holiday and pick-up-point management.	Generic, utilitarian visual design with little distinctive branding.
Several neighbourhood pick-up points offered directly at sign-up.	Homepage feels cluttered, with several competing carousels and news feeds.
Clear diversification: training, schools, community growing, campaigning.	Core social mission is somewhat buried beneath transactional box-scheme content.

4. Sole Food Street Farms (Vancouver, Canada)

https://www.solefoodfarms.com/

Sole Food Street Farms is a social enterprise urban farm operating on vacant and repurposed land in Vancouver's Downtown Eastside. Founded in 2008, it provides low-barrier agricultural employment and a supportive community to residents facing addiction, mental illness, or other obstacles to stable work. Around two-thirds of its produce is sold to restaurants, farmers' markets and through a weekly harvest-box programme, the remainder donated through partner organisations.

Built on Squarespace, the site has a polished, contemporary look, generous white space, and high-quality photography; navigation is short and clear, and the site is fully responsive. The content, however, is comparatively thin, and the harvest-box programme is described but not sold or managed online there is no account, no sign-up form, and no way to choose or change a pick-up point without contacting the farm directly.

Measured against the reading grid, Sole Food illustrates the opposite trade-off from OrganicLea: a strong, modern visual identity achieved on a modest budget, but with essentially no functional autonomy for clients a useful

reminder that a good-looking site and a genuinely useful one are not the same thing.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Clean, contemporary, fully responsive design with strong photography.	Thin content on several pages; some sections feel underdeveloped.
Short, uncluttered navigation, easy to use on any device.	No online ordering, account or self-service for the harvest-box programme.
Clear, concise mission statement on every page.	No blog or news section, and no drop-off-point selection tool.

5. Libera Terra (Italy)

https://liberaterra.it/en/

Libera Terra is a network of social cooperatives in southern Italy that farm land confiscated from mafia organisations under Italian anti-mafia law. Grouped under the Libera Terra Mediterraneo consortium, it is legally required, as a "type B" social cooperative, to employ people disadvantaged in the labour market. Libera Terra produces wine, olive oil, pasta and preserves sold under a shared "legality" brand, and also runs an agritourism arm.

The website is a modern, bilingual (Italian/English) WordPress site with an elegant black, white and olive-green colour scheme, a historical timeline, and an interactive map locating each of the nine member cooperatives. It links out to a specialised e-commerce site (Bottega Libera Terra) and to the tourism arm, keeping the institutional site focused on storytelling rather than transactions; unlike Cocagne, its model is retail and wholesale rather than a basket-subscription / drop-off-point scheme.

Measured against the reading grid, Libera Terra scores highest of the five on federated visual identity a single, recognisable brand shared by nine independent cooperatives but lowest on the specific point-de-dépôt / subscription logic that matters most for the Cocagne project, since its business model simply does not include recurring basket deliveries.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Elegant, coherent bilingual visual identity in Italian and English.	English translation occasionally feels stiff and overly literal.
Clear historical timeline and interactive map of the nine cooperatives.	Core activity (production, e-commerce) is split across several external sub-sites.
Strong civic/educational storytelling around anti-mafia legislation and legality.	No basket-subscription or drop-off-point logic, unlike Cocagne's core commercial model.

6. FRACP Fédération Romande d'Agriculture Contractuelle de Proximité (Switzerland)

https://www.fracp.ch/

The FRACP is the network of "Agriculture Contractuelle de Proximité" (ACP) partnerships across French-speaking Switzerland the Swiss equivalent of the French AMAP / CSA model, linking local producers directly with consumers through subscription baskets of vegetables, fruit and other processed products. Unlike the four organisations above, the FRACP has no formal work-integration mission: its stated purpose is local, ecological, human-scale and food-sovereign agriculture built on solidarity between farmers and consumers, not the professional reintegration of people far from employment. It is nonetheless the comparator structurally closest to the Réseau Cocagne itself, since it is a national (here regional/linguistic) federation of independent local partnerships rather than a single farm.

The FRACP website is a modern, illustrated site built around three clear entry points: understanding the ACP model, finding a basket near you through an interactive map (map.fracp.ch), and starting your own ACP as a producer. The interactive map, which lets a visitor locate a basket-collection point close to home, is the clearest existing equivalent among the five foreign examples to what the Cocagne project calls “point de dépôt” selection. Day-to-day operations (ordering, payment, delivery), however, are left to each local ACP's own tools, so the federation's own site functions mainly as a directory and showcase rather than as an operational back office.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Clean, modern, illustrated design with three clear calls to action for different audiences.	No work-integration or professional-reintegration mission, unlike the Cocagne model.
Interactive map to find a nearby basket / drop-off point closest existing parallel to Cocagne's point de dépôt logic.	The federation site is a directory rather than an operational tool: ordering and payment happen elsewhere, on each local ACP's own pages.
Genuine national (regional) federation structure, directly comparable to the Réseau Cocagne.	Little visible information on how individual ACPs are legally organised or professionalised.

Cross-cutting observations

Front-office autonomy and drop-off points

Client autonomy varies sharply across the six organisations. OrganicLea and, to a lesser extent, FRACP are the only two that let a client choose or change a pick-up / drop-off point without contacting staff OrganicLea through a genuine account dashboard, FRACP through a public interactive map that points visitors to the nearest independent ACP. The Homeless Garden Project sells shares online but leaves any change to staff; Sole Food and Libera Terra offer no comparable self-service logic at all, for different reasons the former by choice of a simple showcase site, the latter because its retail model does not involve recurring deliveries to a drop-off point in the first place.

Visual identity and storytelling

The Homeless Garden Project and Libera Terra put people and history at the centre of their storytelling trainee testimonials for the former, a milestone timeline of anti-mafia legislation for the latter which helps a first-time visitor quickly grasp why the organisation exists, not only what it sells. OrganicLea and Soe Food Street Farms lean further toward the commercial side of the business, which is effective for driving sales but leaves the social mission comparatively less visible on the homepage. FRACP takes a third approach, communicating the ACP model itself (a farming philosophy) rather than the story of any one farm or cooperative, since it speaks on behalf of many independent producers at once.

Federation and scale

Of the six, only Libera Terra and FRACP are themselves federations rather than single farms, which makes them the two most directly comparable, in structure, to the Réseau Cocagne. Both, however, solve the “many structures, one identity” problem by pointing visitors out to separate, independently run sub-sites rather than by offering one shared, configurable software instance which is precisely the gap the SAÉ 5 project is trying to close for the Cocagne network.

Mobile experience

All six organisations appear to use responsive templates that adapt reasonably well to smartphones, though the more content-dense pages (OrganicLea's homepage, Libera Terra's cooperative map, FRACP's basket-finder map) are likely to require more scrolling and pinch-zooming on small screens than the sparser pages of Sole Food Street Farms or the Homeless Garden Project's shop.

Comparative summary

Organisation (country)	Legal form / mission	Advantages	Disadvantages
Les Jardins de Cocagne (France)	1901 association / ACI, work-integration	Established national network; strong, recognised social mission.	Ageing, offline, single-user software; no client self-service.
Homeless Garden Project (USA)	Non-profit, work-integration	Authentic storytelling; integrated Shopify shop.	No self-service subscription management; single pick-up point.
OrganicLea (UK)	Workers' cooperative	Real customer dashboard; several pick-up points.	Generic design; social mission less visible than the shop.
Sole Food Street Farms (Canada)	Social enterprise	Clean, modern, fully responsive design.	No online ordering or account at all.
Libera Terra (Italy)	Network of “type B” social cooperatives	Coherent bilingual identity; strong civic storytelling.	No basket/drop-off model; activity split across sub-sites.
FRACP (Switzerland)	Regional federation of local ACPs	Interactive map to find a basket; federation structure close to Cocagne's.	No work-integration mission; site is a directory, not an operational tool.

Conclusion

The five organisations studied share at least part of the Cocagne network's model organic production linked to a social or solidarity purpose but none combines every element of it in the same way. The Homeless Garden Project and OrganicLea show that a genuine online shop or subscriber account can work well for a paid work-integration farm, and OrganicLea in particular shows that self-service management of pick-up points is achievable on an ordinary e-commerce platform. Sole Food shows that a small organisation can still project a polished, mobile-friendly image with very little functionality behind it. Libera Terra shows how a federation of independent structures can share one visual identity while keeping day-to-day commerce on separate, specialised sites. The FRACP, finally, is the closest structural parallel to the Réseau Cocagne a federation of independent local partnerships and its interactive basket-finder map is the clearest existing model for a national, searchable “point de dépôt” directory, even though it carries no work-integration mission of its own.

For the Cocagne network, the clearest lessons from this benchmark are the value of an integrated, client-facing subscription and drop-off-point management system (as seen at OrganicLea and, partially, at FRACP), of a distinctive and consistent visual identity across a federated network (as seen at Libera Terra and FRACP), and of regularly refreshed content that keeps the human, social side of the project as visible as the vegetables themselves something none of the five comparators fully achieves at the same time as offering genuine online self-service. This combination is precisely what the SAÉ 5 project sets out to build.